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Emirates Tales

English illustrated edition



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Contributors

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A reading edition of the collective book. Author credits remain open to confirmation; Arabic and English translations await collective review.

Introduction

Sometimes a shift in perspective is enough. Leave familiar images behind, listen to a conversation, notice a forgotten object, step into an ordinary place: a story becomes possible. Emirates Tales grew from this invitation to write about the United Arab Emirates through its characters, beyond postcard views.

The book grew out of a workshop at the international conference "Writing and Teaching Writing with Artificial Intelligence across Languages: Literary Creation and Teaching Practices" at Sorbonne University Abu Dhabi. On 30 October 2026, texts took shape through many hands in a literary sprint, with its mishaps, changes of direction and surprises.

The collaborative exquisite corpse shifted each participant's authority. One person introduced a character and a place; others developed the story, introduced tension, imagined an ending or revised the whole. Receiving a story begun by someone else meant reading before writing and carrying another voice forward.

Artificial intelligence could propose a situation, change a phrase or suggest a detail. A choice still had to be made. Fluency guarantees neither accuracy nor literary power: generated suggestions met human intentions, readings and decisions.

Fifteen stories move from a kitchen to a bookbinding workshop, from a library to a bus shelter, from a cinema to a radio studio. Objects often carry what characters leave unsaid: a pearl, a button, a telegram, a photograph or the bottom of a drawer. Humour and unease coexist, without any story claiming to sum up a country.

Moving from French into Arabic and English extends the relay. Assisted programming brought these contributions together as a book and a digital edition: arranging, illustrating and connecting voices. The raw texts remain archived; this edited version preserves distinct tones and open endings.

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STORY 1

Chakhboot and Adam's Return to School

Rafka, Mai Nourelhuda, Celia Ouali, Hana Subhi, Raphael Haddad



Adam had just arrived in the Emirates with his family. For the past few days he had been attending a new school in Abu Dhabi called Théodule Ribot. Everything seemed different: the routines, the expressions, the names and the rhythm. Friendships, too.

Every morning he sat at the back of the classroom. He understood a few words of Arabic and English, but when his classmates all spoke at once, he lost the thread.

That morning, seven boys were playing ball near the pitch.

"Adam, are you coming?" one of them shouted.

Adam hesitated. He had not understood the question.

The boys exchanged a few words and carried on playing. Adam lowered his eyes.

Then a boy came up to him.

"Hi! I'm Chakhboot. Why are you on your own?"

"I don't always understand what people say. I'm afraid I'll give a silly answer."

Chakhboot thought for a moment.

"Can you play football?"

Adam smiled.

"Of course! My favourite player is Harry Kane! He's going to win the Ballon d'Or this year!"

"No way. It'll be Lamine Yamal! Come and play, French boy!"

Chakhboot picked up the ball and went over to the others.

"This is Adam. He's just arrived. He's really good at football."

"Have you played on a team before?" one boy asked.

Adam did not understand every word, but he recognised the word "football". He nodded enthusiastically.

The game began. Adam did what he had dreamed of so often: a nutmeg, then a goal! The boys cheered.

At the end of break, a little girl named Sheina approached with an exercise book.

"Would you like to learn a few words of Arabic? I can help."

Adam agreed. He learned to say "marhaba" and "shukran". Then he taught her a few French words.

Chakhboot watched them trading words with amusement.

"So which do you like better—football or new words?"

On the way back to class, Adam walked in the middle of the group this time.

He still did not understand everything. He still did not know all their names. But for the first time since his arrival, he was looking forward to coming back to school the next day.

STORY 2

The Memory of Pearls

Ilham Binan, Rafka, Mai Nourelhuda, Celia Ouali, Hana Subhi



Anne felt as though she were standing in her kitchen, opening the oven to check on a cake. Yet she was thousands of kilometres away: she had just landed in Dubai.

By the taxis, she pulled her shirt away from her back. The rough suitcase handle pressed into her palm. A horn sounded. The air smelled of petrol and coffee.

At thirty-nine, she knew the excitement of departures. She checked her phone three times, then photographed the sky for her children, who would join her during the holidays.

After her separation, she had left the job advert open on her computer for a long time. An art historian familiar with cultural outreach, she was to help create an exhibition on pearl diving and the memories of Emirati families.

Of the Emirates, she mostly knew the towers. In her bag was a file showing divers whose names no one had recorded.

The driver opened the boot.

Anne put her phone away and lifted her suitcase with both hands.

A week later, Mariam, who had come to lend some family letters, stopped before a photograph.

“That isn’t my grandfather.”

Anne checked the caption.

“But your uncle confirmed—”

“Yes. My uncle.”

Mariam closed her bag. Anne did not press her.

That evening, she found the recording of their first interview. The name was never mentioned. She had copied it from the file without checking.

Then an envelope tore as she was sorting the papers. Two letters fell out. The attached translation spoke of debts the exhibition text never mentioned.

Anne took the documents to her supervisor.

“We need to rewrite this section.”

He gently pushed the pages away.

“Printing starts on Thursday.”

“And the letters?”

He put the cap back on his pen.

“Keep the originals safe.”

Anne remained standing. Behind her, the printer started up.

The next day, Anne handed in a corrected version. The photograph remained, but without the disputed name. Beside it, she proposed a space where families could add their own information. Her supervisor crossed that out. Anne looked at the red line, then slipped copies of the letters into an envelope. She still had rent to pay. At noon she went down to meet Mariam outside the building. She returned the originals, without promising them a place in the exhibition. Mariam counted the sheets. Then she took a photograph from her bag and laid it between them. Three names were written on the back. A fourth had been scratched away.

STORY 3

Bashir's Guests

Alexandra Prevot, Ilham Binan, Rafka, Mai Nourelhuda, Celia Ouali



It is told, you who listen, that in Dubai there lived a cook named Bashir, who had come from Lahore. At night, when the workers' communal kitchen emptied, he opened the vegetable storeroom, and abandoned cats came in like long-awaited guests.

That evening he stroked a thin cat with rough fur. Under his hands, her purring rose in time with the simmering curry. Steam heavy with turmeric and cumin filled the kitchen.

He spoke to the cat while the curry cooked and cooked, forgotten.

With the tip of his spoon, he put some chicken in a saucer. The cat sniffed it, tasted it, then looked up at him.

Bashir had set himself a challenge that year. He was determined to take part in Dubai's famous Food Festival, a celebration of the emirate's culinary

diversity: Emirati, Lebanese, Indian, Iranian and French food, street food and international cuisine. He had an appointment with a local restaurateur, Mariam Al Adladli—an opportunity he had hardly dared hope for.

While he waited for that meeting, he returned to the stove each evening.

That evening, in the kitchen, Bashir smiled at the cat. He was about to speak to her again when a dull noise sounded behind the door. He turned. A young worker had come in, his face closed.

"Have you seen my bag?"

Bashir pointed at the chair by the window. The bag was gone.

"My papers were in it. And the month's wages."

Bashir set down his spoon. The cat had disappeared under a shelf.

Another noise. A pan had slipped on the stove. The curry was boiling over. Bashir turned off the gas, then noticed a small trail of sauce on the floor. It led to the storeroom door.

He stopped. So did the young worker.

"Do you think...?"

Bashir did not answer. He gently opened the door.

The cat was there, curled against the bag. Beside her, a kitten played with a sheet of paper poking out through the zip.

The young man knelt. He retrieved his belongings, then looked at Bashir.

"Is she hungry too?"

Bashir smiled and picked up the saucer.

"Tonight there are four of us for dinner."

STORY 4

The Thread of Time

Fakkar Salsabil, Alexandra Prevot, Ilham Binan, Rafka, Celia Ouali



In a light-filled room in Ras Al Khaimah, Hiba sat among four students. Her voice guided their movements: how to thread a needle, stretch the fabric, let the thread find its way. But as their hesitant fingers worked, one question kept circling inside her, insistent as a hum.

Why?

In 2026, why turn back time to pass on an art the hurried world seemed to have forgotten? Why did these men, too, come seeking the patience of a needle? She loved her work with all her heart, yet doubt crept in: what weight could a silk thread carry in a universe drowned in virtual light?

The morning light seemed to thicken, turning almost golden, like honey. Voices stretched out, distant and slow. The threads on the students' knees seemed to tremble, alive, reaching towards her.

Hiba...

Salima's voice came from very far away and very close at once. Hiba started.

The brightness had vanished. Around her lay a soft, velvety dimness, smelling of old wood and jasmine. She was lying on a soft bed draped in embroidered fabrics whose patterns seemed to breathe in the half-light. Somewhere a glow flickered like a heartbeat.

She slowly sat up, her throat dry.

Where am I?

An image returned, precise and dated. 2011: al sadu weaving, the art of her grandmothers, had appeared on UNESCO's list of endangered traditions. Heritage needing urgent safeguarding—like a language with only a few voices left to carry it. The voices of elderly women, fewer and fewer, sole guardians of gestures inherited from their mothers.

Then something had shifted. The years had passed over it, patient as hands at a loom. Workshops had opened, archives had filled, young people had come to sit beside the elders. And in 2025, the world had changed lists: urgency had become presence. The thread had not broken.

So, Hiba thought, remembering the needles raised around her, 2026 was not a return to the past. It was what came next.

Hiba put her feet on the floor.

An unfamiliar coolness travelled up her legs. She surveyed the room. Old carpets covered the walls. Wooden chests stood in a corner. On a small table a lamp cast an amber light.

Salima stood by the window.

"You've slept a long time, Hiba."

"How long?"

Salima did not answer immediately.

"Long enough to understand certain things."

Hiba frowned.

"I don't understand anything. Where are we?"

Salima came closer and handed her a piece of cloth.

"Look."

It was a piece of al sadu. The geometric patterns were extraordinarily fine. Yet one detail caught her attention: among the red and black shapes, a blue thread discreetly crossed the design.

“This motif isn’t in any pattern I know.”

“That’s natural,” Salima replied. “It’s never been published.”

Hiba looked up.

“Who made it?”

Salima lowered her voice.

“Your grandmother.”

Hiba felt her heart quicken.

Her grandmother had been dead for years. She had learned her first weaving movements beside her, but had never heard of this piece.

“Why hide it from me?”

Salima looked away.

“Because some stories can’t be told in front of everyone.”

She opened an old chest and took out a yellowed envelope.

Inside was a photograph of three women sitting before a loom. One was her grandmother. She did not know the other two.

On the back, a date: 1978.

And a handwritten sentence:

When the last thread disappears, someone will have to begin again.

Hiba reread the words.

“What does that mean?”

Salima sat beside her.

“Your grandmother entrusted those two women with a secret. A secret about passing on their knowledge.”

“What secret?”

Before Salima could answer, a sharp sound came from the corridor.

Someone had opened the front door.

Salima went pale.

“Hide the photograph.”

Footsteps approached.

A woman appeared in the doorway. She carried a canvas bag and a small object wrapped in white cloth.

She looked at Hiba for a long time.

“So it’s you.”

“Do you know me?”

The woman set her parcel on the table.

“I knew your grandmother. She asked me to give you this when you were ready.”

Hiba slowly unfolded the cloth.

Inside lay an old weaving shuttle, worn by the years. A blue thread was still attached to it.

She recognised the colour at once.

The colour of the forbidden motif.

“Why now?”

The woman exchanged a glance with Salima.

“Because tomorrow the house will be sold.”

Hiba turned sharply towards Salima.

“Sold? Why didn’t you tell me?”

Salima said nothing.

The woman continued:

“There’s one more thing. Your grandmother began a piece she never finished. And someone has been trying for a long time to recover what she left behind.”

A new unease came over Hiba.

“Who?”

The woman stood.

“You’ll know when you find the last piece.”

She headed for the door.

“Wait! What last piece?”

But the door closed.

Hiba stood motionless.

The shuttle rested in her hands. The blue thread looked almost new.

She looked at Salima.

“You knew all this?”

Salima did not answer.

“For how long?”

“Since your grandmother died.”

A dull anger rose inside Hiba.

“And you let me teach without telling me?”

Salima lowered her eyes.

“I wanted to protect you.”

“Protect me from what?”

A long silence settled.

Then Salima spoke a few words.

“From what your grandmother discovered.”

Hiba stood up.

She looked at the carpets, the chests, the looms. Suddenly everything seemed different.

Perhaps her work was not simply to pass on an ancient skill.

She had to recover a forgotten story.

On the table, the photograph had slipped. A detail she had not noticed before emerged from beneath the cloth.

A fourth woman stood behind the other three.

Her face was almost erased.

But below it, an inscription remained legible:

To the woman who comes after us.

Hiba felt her hands tremble.

She turned the photograph over.

On the back, one last sentence had been added:

Trust no one, not even the woman who taught you to weave.

Slowly she looked up at Salima.

This time, Salima was no longer smiling.

STORY 5

Behind the Glass Door

Mai Nourelhuda, Fakkar Salsabil, Alexandra Prevot, Ilham Binan, Rafka



In Abu Dhabi, the university corridor shone under the neon lights, still pale with the morning. The air conditioning hummed steadily, while the smell of cardamom coffee and warm paper lingered near the students' room.

Mariam clutched a blue folder, her thumb creasing its edge. Beside her, Saif checked the time on his phone three times, not daring to look at the door.

Noura walked slowly, her bracelets chiming with each step. She studied the colourful posters on the walls, but her eyes kept returning to the two boys.

Youssef leaned against a column, turning a key between his fingers. Each click seemed to count the seconds.

Further away, Lina held a coffee cup whose steam misted her glasses. Now and then she smiled as if to reassure the others, then immediately lowered her head.

No one spoke yet. In that excessively white corridor, their silences crossed like shadows. Outside, Abu Dhabi glittered in the sun; here, behind the glass door, something was waiting to begin.

Behind that door they were to present a project on Talli, a traditional Emirati decorative embroidery skill using metallic and coloured threads.

Inscribed on UNESCO's intangible cultural heritage list in 2022, the art has been passed down for generations, often between women in the same family.

Mariam finally opened her blue folder. Among the photographs and testimonies lay a handwritten letter from her grandmother.

"She said every thread keeps something of the women who wove it," she murmured.

Lina came closer to look at the photographs.

"And what will we keep?"

No one answered.

On the screen above the door, the day's programme had just changed. Their presentation had disappeared.

Saif frantically refreshed his phone.

"Our project's been removed."

"By whom?" Noura asked.

Youssef stopped turning his key.

"I got a message last night."

He did not finish.

Suddenly the glass door opened. An employee told them the room had been booked for an artificial-intelligence demonstration. The testimonies and old objects were no longer on the programme.

Mariam snapped her folder shut.

"They want to show a machine reproducing our grandmothers' patterns?"

Lina checked the presentation tablet. Their video had been replaced by artificially generated images.

“Who sent them our documents?”

Youssef slipped his key into his pocket.

“I thought they would help us.”

Noura moved towards him.

“You gave them the testimonies?”

He nodded.

Then Mariam’s grandmother’s face appeared on the screen, accompanied by words she had never spoken.

Mariam went pale. She recognised her grandmother’s voice at once, but the words were false. She stepped forward and unplugged the tablet. Silence filled the room. Saif picked up his phone. A new message had arrived: “The original archives still exist. Find them before tomorrow.” An address followed. Noura looked at Youssef, who lowered his eyes. He knew the place. It was Mariam’s old family home. No one had returned for years. Outside, the day wore on over Abu Dhabi. They understood that their struggle was no longer just about a project, but about the memory of an entire people.

STORY 6

Hussein

Emilie Crocq, Mai Nourelhuda, Fakkar Salsabil, Alexandra Prevot, Ilham Binan



On the shores of Umm Al Quwain, the evening light lingers as though reluctant to leave the harbour. Hussein stows his sails. The still-warm cloth slips between his thick fingers with a dry rustle, the same movement as always. Around him, hulls knock gently together, ropes creak and somewhere an engine coughs before falling silent. The air smells of salt. Heavy dampness sticks his shirt to his back, laden with fish, mud and plankton. He has known that smell since childhood; it follows him even into sleep. He folds each sail with the same care, slowing at the seams, smoothing creases with his palm. Usually the ritual calms him. Tonight he repeats the same movement twice. His gaze keeps returning to the end of the jetty, where the last golden reflections break in a puddle of oil. He promised to return before dark. At home, someone has probably already placed a glass on the table. Hussein checks one last mooring line, then straightens. A noise comes from

the water beneath the hull. He holds his breath. It is neither the lapping water nor the familiar bump of a fish. “Shou?” he murmurs…

Beneath the hull, something scraped again. Hussein crouched and dipped his fingers in the water. A dark branch had caught in the mooring line. He pulled gently. Fine roots loosened around the rope.

He thought of the emirate’s mangroves, whose roots shelter fish and young turtles. In Umm Al Quwain they play an important role in the coastal ecosystem; the emirate even plans to expand their coverage as part of its blue-economy strategy.

Hussein freed the branch. A small metal box remained wedged beneath the hull. He brought it aboard.

His name was engraved on the lid.

He had not seen it for fifteen years.

The engine coughed behind him.

Hussein turned. Grey smoke rose from the cover. He set the box on deck and ran to the controls.

Nothing.

He pulled the cord. The engine answered with a sharp crack, then died.

Something moved inside the box.

Hussein stood still.

“Did you find it?” a voice asked from the quay.

He recognised Rashid, his younger brother. The one who had never come back.

Hussein did not answer. He held the box against his chest.

The boat drifted slowly. The mooring line tightened, then broke. The quay moved a few metres away.

“Hussein!”

Rashid ran along the planks, his face closed.

Hussein looked at the dark water between them.

“Why now?”

Rashid’s voice shook.

“Because you knew where to look.”

The box opened in Hussein's hands. Inside lay an old photograph wrapped in damp cloth.

The photograph showed two boys before the mangroves of Sinniyah. Rashid held the box; Hussein watched him, before their last trip to sea together. On the back were a date and the words: "I saw what they did."

"You let me go," Rashid said.

"I thought you were dead."

"That was more convenient."

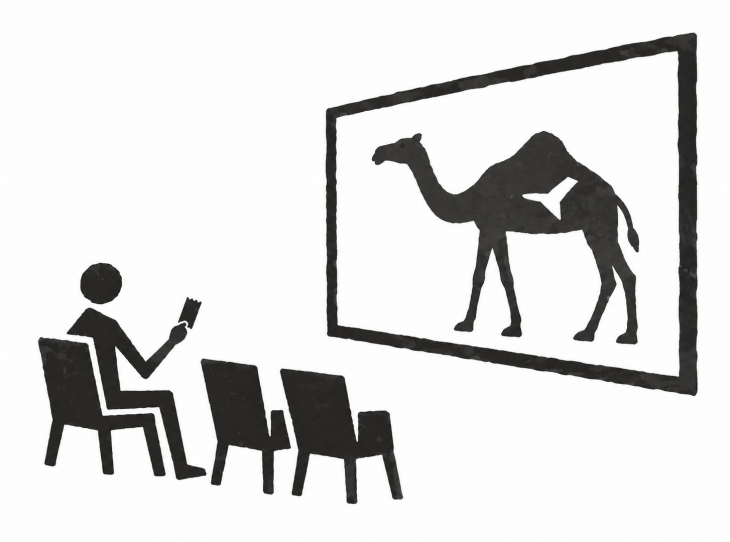
The boat drifted towards the black roots. In Umm Al Quwain's mangroves, fish shelter among the roots; Hussein knew that. At rising tide, no one would hear the missing engine.

Rashid jumped aboard. The box fell. It sank. Then he cut the remaining line. This time, Hussein did not cry out.

STORY 7

The Pale Mark

Clemence Wiley, Emilie Crocq, Fakkar Salsabil, Alexandra Prevot



The velvet of the seat is worn where Hasan rests his hands. He dislikes enclosed rooms. This one smells of lukewarm popcorn, the concrete of the old warehouse, and the oud perfume of the young woman to his right. The air conditioning blows hard.

The lights go out. A faint crackle, then the desert fills the screen.

Hasan sits up. A camel crosses the frame slowly, head high, a pale mark on its left flank. He knows that mark. His fingers tighten on the armrest, then loosen. He leans forward, so close to the seat ahead that its occupant turns around.

He murmurs a name. No one hears.

On screen, the camel stops and stares into the camera. Hasan raises his hand to his mouth and keeps it there for a long time.

When the shot changes, he stands, steps over his neighbour's legs without apologising and walks out into the white light of Al Quoz, the crumpled ticket deep in his pocket.

Hasan stops beneath the FrancoFilm poster. French-Arab co-productions whose programme he had barely glanced at on entering. Now he searches for a name, a date, anything that might explain why his camel is in this film.

He closes his eyes. The shot returns: a sideways tracking shot at the animal's height. Then the cut to that gaze, almost a close-up. The camera was very near. Who was holding it?

Behind the door, the music plays on, muffled. Hasan unfolds his ticket on his thigh. The paper is damp. He returns to the desk and waits for the young woman to look up.

"The film. When was it shot?"

She reaches towards the programme.

"Do you want the director's name?"

Hasan shakes his head.

"I want to know where it was."

The young woman leafs through the programme and stops. Her hand barely trembles.

"Dubai. Three years ago, according to the notes."

Hasan nods. Three years, almost to the day.

"Do you know someone there?"

"Someone owed me a camel."

She does not smile. She looks at the flickering strip light.

"The projector coughed up dust earlier. Nobody knows why."

Hasan says nothing. He can taste dust on his tongue.

She prints the contacts page. The machine creaks, then suddenly stops. The sheet is warm.

"It had the same mark," she says.

"What did?"

"Nothing. Sorry."

In the corridor his phone vibrates: a name he has not dialled for a long time. He lets it ring. On the last ring, the film's music stops behind the door.

A breath of wind slips under the closed doors. Hasan folds the sheet and leaves.

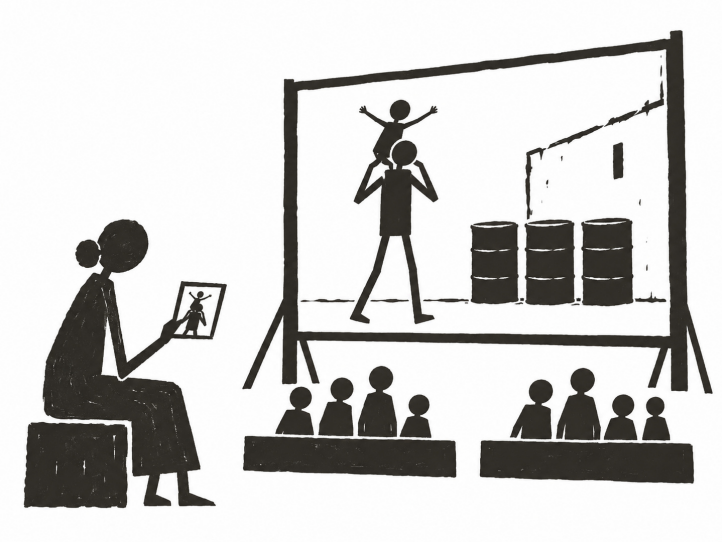
Outside, his car is gone. Hasan unfolds the sheet. The production contacts have vanished. One handwritten line remains: a coordinate. He hears a slow step behind him. Warm breath on his neck. He does not turn. He knows what he would see.

He slips the ticket into his pocket, places his hand on the invisible neck and walks east.

STORY 8

The Wall Comes Alive Again

Marie-Astrid Morvan, Clemence Wiley, Emilie Crocq, Mai Nourelhuda, Fakkar Salsabil



Set like a feather in the middle of the sea, she seemed luminous in the empty auditorium. No one could have guessed what she was about to see or why she was there. In this city that had emerged from the desert, she seemed to belong neither to today nor to tomorrow. She was simply there, to live and dream. The room was filled with one of those smells that carry you back to childhood just when you would rather escape it, light and heavy at once…

She would have recognised that smell among a thousand: warm petrol mingled with dust. She had been six that May evening when her father lifted her onto an old oil drum, among other drums lined up beneath Sharjah's sky. Nearby, English airmen laughed loudly. Before her, a plain white-washed wall had suddenly begun to move, speak, breathe. She gripped the cold metal and no longer dared blink, afraid everything would disappear.

Now velvet had replaced iron; the wall had become a screen. Yet beneath the armrest her fingers still searched for the rough rim of a drum. When the lights dimmed, she sat very straight, just as she had that evening, ready for the wall to come alive again.

The image appeared, trembled, then vanished. A sharp crack crossed the room. She stayed upright. In the dark, a door opened.

"You can wait outside," a young man said.

"I'm comfortable here."

He hesitated. His torch lit her clenched hands.

"Are you cold?"

She hid them beneath her bag.

"Will you start it again from the beginning?"

"You haven't missed anything."

At last she turned towards him.

"You can't know that."

He lowered his torch and left.

A few minutes later, the projector started again. This time a photograph filled the screen. Drums. A white wall. In the front row, a man carried a little girl on his shoulders.

She stood. Her bag fell. A lipstick rolled under the seat.

"Wait."

The young man reappeared.

"Madam?"

She pointed to the screen.

"That picture. Don't take it away."

The young man looked at the screen, then at the woman.

"Do you recognise him?"

She did not answer. Her fingers searched her bag until they found an old envelope. The paper had yellowed. She took out a photograph folded in two.

The same wall. The same drums. The same man.

But on the back was a handwritten sentence:

So you remember that everything began here.

She moved towards the screen. The image trembled again. Her father's face blurred, then disappeared.

"He died in this city," she said.

The young man stayed near the door.

"Would you like me to stop the screening?"

She shook her head.

"No. Let him go."

He returned to the booth. The photograph slowly faded, replaced by the film.

The woman sat down again. She rested her hands on the armrests, then closed her eyes.

In the empty auditorium, the projector kept breathing. When she opened her eyes, the screen no longer showed her past. Only a white road, open before her.

STORY 9

The Seyb's Silence

Alexis Collet, Marie-Astrid Morvan, Clemence Wiley, Emilie Crocq, Mai Nourelhuda



The taxi dropped him outside a small bicycle repair workshop in an Ajman street. He stood still for a few seconds, suitcase in hand.

The former Marine colonel had served in the Middle East for years. Yet he knew little of the Emirates. He had expected towers and broad avenues. Here, shops lined the ground floors of modest buildings.

In the workshop, a chain grated over a sprocket. The smell of rubber and grease lingered among the bicycles hanging on the wall.

He wiped his glasses and checked his phone. Still no message from Daniel.

His son had asked him to come to this address before leaving on another mission. Since then, silence.

The mechanic looked up.

“Are you Daniel’s father?”

The colonel nodded.

The man put down his tools, slowly wiped his hands and pointed to a chair.

“Sit down. Your son left something for you.”

He took a small cloth pouch from a drawer.

“He asked me to give you this in person.”

Inside lay an old pearl. The colonel recognised it immediately. It had belonged to his maternal great-grandfather, who had made a living diving for pearls in the Gulf before the family emigrated to the United States.

He remembered the family stories. Divers descended without breathing equipment, carrying a nose clip called a fettam, an oyster basket, the deyeen, and a stone tied to a rope to hasten their descent. At the surface another man, the seyb, held the rope and watched over their return.

Every dive depended on trust between two men.

Daniel had always been fascinated by that story. As a child he would ask to hold the pearl.

The colonel closed his fingers around the pouch.

The mechanic was now searching the bottom of the drawer for something else. He pulled out an old phone with a cracked screen.

“He also left a recording.”

Daniel’s voice emerged through bursts of static.

“Dad, if you speak on the radio, don’t reveal their positions.”

Then silence.

“What positions does he mean?” the mechanic asked.

The colonel did not answer.

His own phone rang. A journalist from a Ras Al Khaimah radio station wanted to interview him live about military tensions in the Gulf. She wanted him to confirm information about an operation underway.

“Have you received the documents our source sent you?”

“Yes.”

“Can you identify the positions?”

He looked at the pouch in his hand.

“I could.”

“I’ll call you back for the live broadcast. We start in a few minutes.”

She hung up.

The colonel tried to replay Daniel’s message. The old phone’s screen flickered, then went dark: the battery was dead. He could not hear the rest.

He dialled his son’s number. No answer.

The mechanic picked up his spanner.

“Are you going to speak?”

The colonel sat beside a dismantled wheel.

“I don’t know yet.”

His phone rang again. This time they were on air. The journalist asked him to confirm the coordinates he had received. The colonel took the pearl from the pouch and laid it on the bench beside a bicycle chain.

“My son asked me not to disclose them.”

“You realise we’re live?”

He did. In the workshop, the mechanic kept turning a wheel. A rubbing sound returned with every revolution.

“I can speak about what I’ve seen. Not about what would put lives at risk.”

The line was cut. The colonel picked up the pearl and closed his hand around it, like the seyb gripping the rope. He remained in front of the phone, not knowing whether his son had heard him.

STORY 10

The Key Photograph

Aya Bouebdelli, Alexis Collet, Marie-Astrid Morvan, Clemence Wiley, Emilie Crocq



In Al Ain, in the United Arab Emirates, Mariam, a sixteen-year-old Emirati girl, pushed open the door of her grandfather's old bookbinding workshop. The smell of yellowed paper and dried glue filled the room. Beneath her fingers, the counter's flaking wood seemed to hold the traces of thousands of repaired books. Outside, horns mingled with passers-by's conversations. Inside, only an old fan's hum disturbed the silence. Since her grandfather's death, Mariam had never dared return. That morning, however, she had to empty the workshop before it closed for good.

Years later, Mariam would run a start-up incubator in Abu Dhabi. But that morning, while sorting the workshop's last belongings, she discovered an old camera, carefully preserved, and a photograph of Al Ain's palm groves. In it she could make out the irrigation channels, the aflaj, those ingenious systems that have carried water through the desert for centuries.

She studied the picture for a long time. Why had her grandfather wanted to capture that scene? Was it simply its beauty, or the change he had wished to record?

A thought came to her: her grandfather, too, had been curious about his time. He had not tried to stop time, but to preserve its traces.

"In the end, we aren't so different," she thought.

She understood that her inheritance was not to preserve the past, but to continue its movement.

She stumbled over a pile of books and accidentally pressed the camera's shutter. A flash dazzled her. Seized by violent dizziness and nausea, she did not open her eyes for several minutes. The place was the same; only its atmosphere had changed.

"Hello, Mariam! What became of the promise you made me?"

"Grandfather, what are you talking about?"

"Bringing my workshop back to life, restoring its original soul. And don't forget... giving Sharjah back its former beauty."

In the blink of an eye she was back, ready to fulfil lost hopes and bring a glimmer to what had lost its light. To find meaning in a message that had not been fully delivered.

That evening Mariam had the film left in the camera developed. Only one image was sharp: a young man bent over an open book in a narrow shop. On its window, a hand-painted sign bore a name and a city: Sharjah. The first workshop. The one nobody mentioned.

The next day, Mariam nevertheless signed the closure papers. The lease had been sold, the debts were too heavy. She saved nothing.

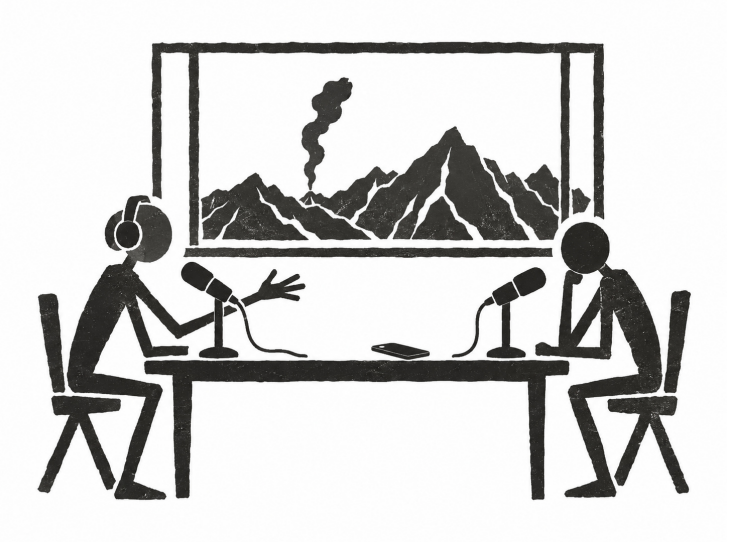
A promise is not always kept where it was made.

But she slipped the photograph into her bag and left, mentally deciding which wall at home she would hang it on.

STORY 11

The Frequency of Silence

Hugues De vaulx, Aya Bouebdelli, Alexis Collet, Marie-Astrid Morvan, Clemence Wiley



In the small studio of Radio Ras Al Khaimah, Captain James Whitmore adjusted his headphones. At sixty, the former US Navy officer had lived through two wars and learned to distrust silences.

The air conditioning hummed above the acoustic panels. The smell of Arabic coffee mingled with the warmed plastic of the consoles. Beyond the glass, the Hajar Mountains disappeared in an ochre haze of dust.

Opposite him, Leila Al Mansouri, an Emirati journalist, checked her microphone.

"Captain, do you think this war with Iran will be short?"

Whitmore slowly placed his glasses on the table. His wedding ring struck the water glass.

"That's always what we hope at the beginning."

Leila noticed he was avoiding her eyes.

On the wall screen, a map of the Strait of Hormuz flashed. Small red dots represented military vessels.

Whitmore knew every one of those passages. He had commanded men there.

Today he commanded none.

And that did not reassure him.

Leila pointed to the map.

“Why would the Emirates be affected?”

Whitmore leaned towards the microphone.

“Look at this strip of water. The Strait of Hormuz. At its narrowest point, just thirty-nine kilometres. And a considerable share of the world’s oil passes through it.”

He stopped. His phone had vibrated.

A message from his former command.

Situation evolving. Remain available.

He turned the device over.

“The Emirates have known about that vulnerability for a long time,” he continued. “They even built a pipeline to carry oil from Abu Dhabi to Fujairah without passing through the strait.”

“So we’re protected?”

Whitmore studied the microphone’s red light.

“A pipeline can bypass a sea passage, Leila. Not a war.”

Outside, a rumble crossed the sky.

Nobody asked whether it was an aircraft.

Leila noticed that Whitmore was looking more at the map of the Emirates than at the strait.

“Captain, you seem concerned about something other than this war.”

He smiled faintly.

“Forty years ago, I met a man who told me something I never forgot. An old man. He spoke of a strength measured less by what we control than by what we build.”

He paused.

“At the time, I didn’t understand. I was a young officer. I thought in terms of power, territory and security. Today I’ve returned to the Emirates to understand those words. Not to find that man, who is no longer with us, but to understand what he built and what it means.”

Leila set down her pen. For the first time, the interview was taking a different direction.

“Have you understood, Captain?”

“Building takes a whole lifetime, Leila. Yet a single second is enough to destroy everything.”

Their faces had changed. They understood each other.

The siren outside tore through the studio’s silence, drowning out the air conditioning’s persistent hum. On the wall screen, red dots had spread across the entire map, merging into an incandescent tide. Whitmore rose slowly, mechanically adjusted his shirt collar and looked through the great dusty window. In the distance, the Hajar Mountains vanished beneath thick black smoke. Leila remained motionless, her pen still between her fingers, staring at the device that was still recording.

STORY 12

The Telegram That Never Left

Raphael Haddad, Hugues De vaulx, Aya Bouebdelli, Alexis Collet, Marie-Astrid Morvan



Obaid Al Neyadi had transmitted telegrams for thirty years. Now he bound books in Al Ain, sewing each gathering in Morse: short dot, long dash. It amused him. It was his signature. Nobody knew.

That morning, a young woman placed a leather diary from 1994 on his bench. Its spine was split, its pages warped by spilled tea. Her father's. She said nothing more.

Obaid ran his thumb along the edge, rough as a cat's tongue. He opened the starch paste; a smell of warm rice rose and mingled with wet cardboard. He did not look at her. He tapped the sheets against the wood three times, then three more, though they were already straight.

The screw press creaked under his palm. Linen thread whistled through the paper.

She stood holding her bag against her stomach. At last she sat on the stool he had pushed towards her, wordlessly, an hour earlier.

At the final gathering, Obaid stopped. He undid three stitches and began again, more slowly.

In the stitching he had written the first name he had read on the flyleaf.

Obaid gently pulled the last thread. The name, Mariam, was now disappearing into the binding, invisible to anyone who did not know Morse.

The young woman came closer.

“Have you finished?”

“Almost.”

He wiped the cover. Beneath his fingers, the leather had regained its suppleness. A drop of paste still shone near the edge.

Outside, the call to prayer mingled with the rustling oasis palms. The smell of warm dust entered through the half-open window.

“My father wrote every evening,” she said.

Obaid nodded.

“Has he died?”

“Three weeks ago.”

The old man put down his needle.

She opened the diary at the final page. A single sentence appeared in shaky handwriting:

There are things I never knew how to tell her.

Obaid watched Mariam’s hands. She was mechanically rubbing her thumb against her forefinger.

He knew that gesture.

He had once seen it in men waiting for telegrams.

Obaid closed the diary.

“Did your father live in Al Ain?”

“A long time ago. He worked near the oasis.”

She pointed towards the window.

“He said the gardens had their own way of passing messages.”

Obaid smiled.

He remembered the old falaj channels, irrigation networks carrying water to the palm groves. Al Ain's oasis was part of the cultural sites inscribed on UNESCO's World Heritage List in 2011.

"Water moves even when we can't see it," he murmured. "Like words."

Mariam turned a page.

A yellowed envelope had appeared between two warped sheets.

It bore a date: 17 October 1994.

And a name.

Obaid Al Neyadi's.

The bookbinder felt his fingers stiffen.

At first, the name had awakened no memory.

Now he was unsure.

Mariam opened the envelope. An old telegram form slipped onto the bench.

Obaid immediately recognised the yellowed paper and the stamp of the office where he had worked.

"Did you know my father?"

The old man adjusted his glasses. A memory returned: one October evening, a man had come to the counter with a message already written. He had asked for it to be read before sending.

"I think so," he replied.

Mariam unfolded the form.

"Yet it was never sent."

Obaid saw his own signature at the bottom. Beside it, two words: "Transmission cancelled."

"Were you the one who cancelled it?"

He did not answer.

Mariam turned the paper towards him.

"Why?"

Obaid looked at the workshop door. He now remembered the man's last request.

But he did not know whether Mariam was ready to hear it.

Obaid remained silent for a long time. He took the telegram between his fingers as though afraid the paper might tear. Then he sat down and began to read.

"My dear Obaid,

I don't know whether I will ever find the words to tell you what these years have meant to me. Our afternoons, our conversations, our books and our music will remain among the happiest memories of my life.

I leave tomorrow. I don't know whether I will ever return to Al Ain. But I am not only leaving this city. I am leaving behind a brother I never knew how to call by that name.

Thank you for the time we spent together, for your friendship and everything you gave me.

Your friend."

His voice had broken slightly on the last words.

Mariam said nothing. She watched the man who, in a few minutes, had returned to her a part of her father she had never known.

Obaid laid the telegram on the table.

"Your father and I had a habit. Every afternoon after work he came to my house. We listened to Cairo Radio. Umm Kulthum sang. We knew her songs by heart. We sang along, sometimes until nightfall. We talked about books, poetry, music. We needed little else."

He smiled, as though the singer's voice still echoed in the room.

"We were very different, your father and I. We didn't move in the same circles. But none of that mattered in my house, around that radio. He was my friend. More than that, I think. My brother."

He lowered his eyes to the telegram.

"When he gave it to me, I read it. I should have sent it. But I couldn't. I felt ashamed. Not of him. Of myself, for not knowing how to answer words so simple and so important. Where we came from, we didn't say such things easily. We felt them, but we didn't say them. So I cancelled the transmission."

He paused.

"Then he left. For Canada. I never saw him again."

Mariam gently took the telegram.

STORY 13

The Drawer of the Absent

Hana Subhi, Hugues De vaulx, Aya Bouebdelli, Alexis Collet



In a furniture repair workshop in Sharjah, Youssef, a Syrian cabinetmaker in his fifties, had been working since dawn. A quiet man with precise movements, he spoke more to his furniture than to his customers.

The smell of freshly sanded wood mingled with warm glue. An old saw's creak crossed the workshop, while morning light drew golden bands across the dusty floor.

That day, Youssef was restoring an old walnut chest of drawers. Passing his hand over its rough surface, he felt a slight irregularity. He stopped, adjusted his glasses and gently tapped the bottom of a drawer.

A hollow sound.

He slipped his screwdriver under a thin board. It lifted, revealing a yellowed envelope.

Youssef wiped his hands on his apron. He hesitated, then opened it.

Inside, a photograph showed a young woman before a house he knew.

His fingers began to tremble.

On the back, a sentence in Arabic:

“If you find this photograph, there is still time.”

Suddenly someone knocked on the workshop door.

Youssef hurriedly slipped the photograph under his apron.

An elderly man entered, leaning on a cane.

“Have you found something?”

“Why do you ask?”

“This chest belonged to my sister. She brought it from Damascus.”

Youssef knew the journeys such old furniture made. Some pieces had crossed several borders before reaching homes in Sharjah, whose commitment to heritage had been recognised by UNESCO when it was designated World Book Capital in 2019.

But this chest told another story.

The house in the photograph was in his old Damascus neighbourhood. He recognised its blue door.

Above all, he recognised the young woman.

It was Salma, his younger sister, who had disappeared during the war.

Youssef put his hand on the drawer.

“Where is your sister now?”

The old man lowered his eyes.

“That is precisely why I came.”

“Is your sister dead?” Youssef asked.

The old man shook his head.

“No. She’s in Damascus. But she hasn’t spoken for years.”

He took out another photograph. The same house. The same blue door. This time Salma held a child in her arms.

Youssef felt his heart race.

“Who is that child?”

“She said it was yours.”

A crushing silence filled the workshop.

Suddenly the old man's phone rang. He answered, listened for a few seconds, then held it out to Youssef.

"It's her."

Youssef slowly raised it to his ear.

"Salma?"

No reply.

Only breathing.

Then three light knocks, as though against wood.

Youssef closed his eyes.

It was their old childhood signal.

Someone had returned.

But thirty years now lay between them.

Youssef stood motionless, the phone against his ear. Then, slowly, he knocked three times on the wood of the chest.

Three knocks answered.

His eyes filled with tears.

"Salma… I searched for you for so long."

The old man gently put a hand on his shoulder.

"My sister took in Salma and the child in Damascus. They tried to find you for years. When we discovered you had this workshop in Sharjah, I decided to bring you the chest."

"And the child?" Youssef asked, his voice trembling.

"His name is Adam. He is your son. You believed him dead, but Salma saved him. He has grown up now. He knows your story."

Youssef sat on his old stool. All those years he had learned to live with absence. He had never imagined a simple drawer could overturn so many certainties.

"Would he agree to meet me?"

The old man smiled gently.

"He is the one who asked me to find you."

Youssef looked at the photograph one last time. Then he took a pencil and a sheet of paper.

“Give me their address.”

Before hanging up, he whispered:

“Salma, this time I’ll come.”

Three knocks sounded again through the phone.

Youssef placed the photograph in plain sight on his bench. He closed the envelope but left the drawer open.

For the first time in years, the past no longer seemed like a closed door.

STORY 14

Six Buttons and a Deluge

Celia Ouali, Raphael Haddad, Hugues De vaulx, Aya Bouebdelli



It was twenty past four. In an Al Ain library, Nouka had spread his jacket on a table and taken out a sewing kit from his hotel room.

Outside, rain drummed on the awning. Inside, the smell of matcha drifted between the shelves.

Nouka, who had survived several journeys through the desert, had just lost a fight with a button.

He tried to sew it back on, holding his jacket between his knees.

"Are you a surgeon?" his neighbour asked.

"No. Why?"

"You look as though you're performing a delicate operation."

The man, an Emirati in his sixties, came closer.

"We don't mend clothes like that here."

“How do you do it?”

“We ask our mother.”

Nouka burst out laughing.

“And if she lives ten thousand kilometres away?”

“Then you have a real problem.”

The old man pulled up a chair.

“My name is Hamad. Show me that button.”

He examined it with the solemnity of a forensic expert.

“Oh yes. A complicated case.”

“Have you seen the rain?” Hamad asked.

“Hard to miss. I thought I was coming to the desert!”

“Then you should have been here in April 2024.”

He described the historic rainfall that had struck the Emirates. At Khatm Al Shakla, near Al Ain, 254.8 millimetres had fallen in less than twenty-four hours.

“Even football had to wait! Al Ain’s match against Al Hilal was postponed.”

“You’re joking?”

“We can move a lot of things here. But a football match is serious.”

Hamad smiled.

“And the funny thing is, we’ve had oases for centuries thanks to the falaj, channels that distribute water to the palms.”

Nouka looked at his button.

“Can you irrigate jackets too?”

“No. But we have good tailors.”

Hamad began sewing on the button.

On the third stitch, the needle broke.

“Poor quality,” he announced.

“It’s a free kit.”

“Exactly.”

He took out his phone.

“I’ll call my son. He knows someone.”

"For a needle?"

"For everything. That's the Emirates."

Ten minutes later, a young man entered carrying a small box.

"Dad, you made me come for a button?"

"Not just any button. A French visitor's."

The son examined the jacket.

"But this is the wrong button!"

Nouka sighed.

"There are different categories of buttons?"

"Of course. This one comes from a kandoura."

Hamad burst out laughing.

"That's why it won't stay on!"

Nouka looked at his jacket.

He was beginning to wish he had bought a more conventional souvenir.

The son produced a new button and sewed it on in seconds.

"How much do I owe you?" Nouka asked.

Hamad looked offended.

"You're our guest!"

He ordered three coffees and some dates.

An hour later, Nouka knew the whole family, had two dinner invitations and had promised to attend Al Ain's next match.

The rain had stopped.

He put on his jacket, thanked his new friends and headed for the exit.

"Wait!" Hamad shouted.

Nouka turned.

"What now?"

"Your button!"

He looked at his sleeve.

This time it was the zip that had broken.

STORY 15

Divorce, Monsoon and a Bus Card

Celia Ouali, Hana Subhi, Raphael Haddad, Hugues De vaulx



It was twenty past five. In Mussafah, Abu Dhabi, Hannah was waiting for the bus. Rain hammered the shelter's metal roof. The smell of diesel and hot samosas floated in the air.

At forty-two, Hannah worked in the accounts department of a garage. She knew the unpaid invoices, the late suppliers and the drivers who always promised to arrive "in five minutes".

That morning she had taken half a day off to get divorced.

In her bag, the official papers lay beside an untouched lunch and a broken umbrella. She checked that the documents were dry.

A man in blue overalls sat beside her.

"Are you waiting for a bus or a boat?"

"The bus. But I'm beginning to wonder."

“I’m from Kerala. We know the monsoon there. Here, when it rains, even the cars look surprised!”

Hannah smiled.

Her phone still showed a twelve-minute wait.

She opened her shopping list and added: “Buy a waterproof jacket.”

Then, after some thought: “And perhaps a boat.”

The man opened his bag and offered her a samosa.

“You know, in April 2024 the Emirates had their heaviest rainfall since records began in 1949!”

“And nobody thought of bringing in gondolas?”

“In Mussafah? With all these garages, we’d put engines on them!”

Hannah burst out laughing.

A Pakistani mechanic came out of the neighbouring garage, spanner in hand.

“Still waiting for the bus?”

“Yes. But apparently I ought to learn to swim.”

“Have you got your Hafilat card?”

Hannah patted her bag.

“Of course. Here you can’t get on the bus without it.”

The mechanic nodded.

“Welcome to Abu Dhabi. You can organise everything except the weather.”

Another gust shook the shelter.

Hannah pulled her jacket tighter.

She was beginning to wonder whether her divorce had been the easiest part of her day.

Her phone vibrated.

“Have you signed?” Her former husband.

Hannah typed “yes”, then deleted it.

A gust turned her umbrella inside out. Her bag fell. The divorce papers scattered.

“Madam, your freedom is flying away!” shouted the Indian man, running after a sheet.

The Pakistani mechanic caught two more.

"Are you handing out invoices?"

"No, divorces!"

"Ah! Then keep the originals!"

Everyone laughed.

The bus arrived.

Hannah searched her bag. No wallet. No Hafilat card.

"My wallet's disappeared!"

The Indian man checked his pockets.

"I've only got samosas."

The driver closed the doors.

Hannah watched the bus leave.

Her phone rang.

"Are you coming home tonight?" her former husband asked.

"No. I'm starting my life over."

"Already?"

"Yes. With two mechanics and a samosa seller."

Hannah looked at her companions.

"What now?"

The mechanic offered her a lift. The man from Kerala handed her one last samosa.

"Where I come from, nobody stays alone in the rain."

Her phone vibrated again. Her former husband wanted to know where she would sleep.

She replied: "Somewhere the roof doesn't leak."

The mechanic inspected her inside-out umbrella.

"Madam, you don't need a husband. You need a garage."

Hannah laughed, then searched her pocket.

Her wallet was there.

She had looked everywhere except there.

"In the end," she said, "I'll save the bus for tomorrow."

From traces to images

One image for each story, beginning with a gesture or an object: feeding a cat, offering a photograph, repairing a button, holding a pearl. The images accompany the stories without closing down their meaning.

Monochrome figures on white draw freely on petroglyphs of the Arabian Peninsula and the Hajar Mountains. These are contemporary interpretations, not archaeological reproductions. Phones, buses and cameras belong within this language of signs.

The AI-generated illustrations were selected to form a coherent series. White space leaves room for imagination; the line evokes traces, memory and transmission. The same image accompanies all three languages, offering a meeting place for their voices.

Making the book

The EFEIA workshop took place on 30 October 2026, from 3.30 to 5.30 pm, at Sorbonne University Abu Dhabi. Proposed by Xavier Fresquet and led by the conference organisers, it brought together the fourteen contributors represented in this book.

Five relays guided the writing: character and setting, factual research, tension and events, ending, and revision. The original constraint was a story of at most 600 words, with an ending of 100 words, avoiding the French words for heat, sand and luxury. Longer contributions and open endings have been retained.

The English translations were prepared with AI assistance and aligned with the edited French texts. They remain open to collective review. Credits come from contribution tables and signatures and remain subject to confirmation. Declared tools reproduce participant statements, rather than independently verified technical records. Original texts are archived separately.

The indexes retain the common French or Roman-script entries used in the other editions. They refer to occurrences in the stories; characters sharing a name are distinguished by their story.

Declared tools, story by story

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The Memory of Pearls
Claude 3.5 Sonnet, Gemini 1.5 Pro

Bashir's Guests
ComparIA (plateforme d'évaluation / benchmark)

The Thread of Time
Claude 3.5 Sonnet, Mistral Large 2

Behind the Glass Door
Claude 3.5 Sonnet

Hussein
50/50 Co-écriture humaine + GPT-4o, ComparIA

The Pale Mark
50/50 Co-écriture humaine + GPT-4o, Claude 3.5 Haiku, Claude 3.5 Sonnet

The Wall Comes Alive Again
Claude 3.5 Sonnet, GPT-4o

The Seyb's Silence
Mistral NeMo, Gemini 1.5 Pro, Claude 3 Opus, GPT-4o

The Key Photograph
Claude 3.5 Sonnet

The Frequency of Silence
GPT-4o, Gemini 1.5 Flash

The Telegram That Never Left
Claude 3 Opus (temperature/effort max), GPT-4o mini, GPT-4o (ChatGPT Plus / GPT-4)

The Drawer of the Absent
GPT-4o mini, GPT-4o (ChatGPT Plus / GPT-4)

Six Buttons and a Deluge

Claude 3.5 Sonnet, GPT-4o

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OpenAI o1-preview, Claude 3.5 Sonnet

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Marie-Astrid Morvan

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A cook welcomes cats into his kitchen. A photograph restores a forgotten past. A troublesome button becomes a family affair. Beneath a bus shelter, a divorce turns into an unexpected conversation. Fifteen collaborative stories reveal unexpected Emirates, through ordinary gestures, memory, secrets and humour. Illustrated with monochrome figures freely inspired by Hajar Mountains petroglyphs, this book invites us to discover what we can invent together.

Edited by

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